

releases its packages just the way the developers want it. No unnecessary re-branding or post-modification of code is done. This property makes Slackware simpler than most, but what does this entail in the long run? Simple: there's no fancy boot-up splash screen like Ubuntu, Mandriva or OpenSUSE; there are no special pre-installed themes or other eye-candy; you get only the default appearance of KDE or XFCE, whichever you choose.

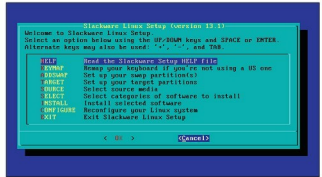
Of course, you can choose to modify your system according to your own preferences, but for newbies, that's easier said than done. Why? Let's look at *pkgtool*, Slackware's default package-management tool. In the 21st century, there are countless Linux distributions with their own package management tools but Slackware's 'pkgtool' seems the most cynical of them all, believing that automatic dependency resolution is not a part of its job description! All it does is install, remove and upgrade packages—nothing more, nothing less. Slackware believes that users are responsible for what they install or remove from their system, and should have the complete freedom to do so. Dependency tracking only gets in the way of this goal!

While this may initially sound preposterous, it's a blessing in disguise for some. Popular package managers like *aptitude*, *urpmi*, *zypper*, *pacman*, *emerge*, etc, may differ in internal coding structures and design layouts, but they all do a common job: maintain packages! When users ask to install a package, they are prompted with a list of extra packages (dependencies) that need to be installed in order to get the desired package working. This is not always a good thing. For example: Abiword is a text editor. It depends on a few GNOME libraries to run. Ubuntu lists 42 necessary dependencies and five optional dependencies! Slackware, on the other hand, lists only three optional 'useless' dependencies, which are mentioned at slackbuilds.org (the most commonly used Slackware user repository). You don't need any extra dependencies to build an Abiword package in Slackware.

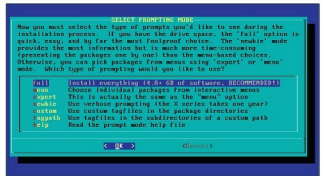
So why does Ubuntu install a load of stuff that's not required? Obviously because Ubuntu is pre-packaging its binaries with every possible dependency, to enable all features, and maybe some extra features, without the user's consent or need for those features. While this may sound like a great prospect to new users, for expert users it is a negative point. Linux is about choice; it's about freedom. If you take away the freedom from users, then what's the point of using Linux instead of Windows?

Slackware addresses this problem tactfully. It lets users decide what features they want—they have to manually configure and compile the package. Usually, all configuration options and features can be discovered by running the following command (in the directory where the source is extracted):

```
./configure --help
```



Slackware Setup Menu



Select Setup Type

If you don't have a printer, why would you keep unnecessary printing-related packages and libraries? All you have to do is pass the `--disable-print` option to *configure*. If you don't need spelling support, pass `--disable-spell`. The moral of the story: Slackware is targeted at users who want complete control over their system, whereas in Ubuntu and other 'user-friendly' distros, the decisions have been made by the developers, for the users. Here is where Slackware wins!

Pros

As mentioned earlier, the manual configuration gives expert users complete control of the system. This doesn't mean intermediate users can't touch Slack! Slackware installation is *ncurses*-based (no fancy point-and-click graphical menus) and provides interactive text menus with detailed information of the packages being installed. There are six different methods of installation to choose from, though the 'full' install option is recommended for a better experience. After the installation is over, all you have to do is edit a few text files to get started.

Slackware is shipped with a huge collection of carefully hand-picked applications that you might require for your daily use. The default download size is a 4 GB DVD, which has the installation binary packages plus the source packages. Slackware doesn't include a single closed-source proprietary package. To install other